

What Makes a Story Truly Epic?



EPIC OF KINGS

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Hi! I'm Jack. Welcome to the Epic of Kings journal. This is my first post... so cool!

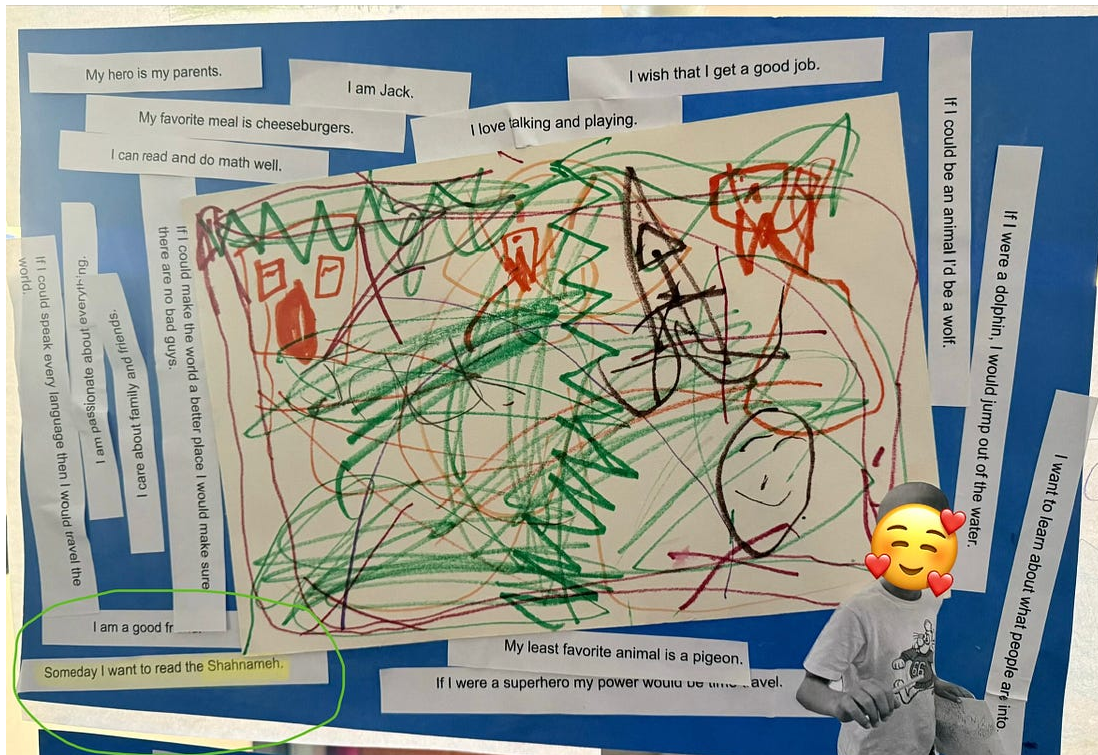
I've wanted to start a website about the *Shahnameh* (the Persian epic of kings) for so long. Ever since I was 6 and my Babayi (grandpa) gave me a copy of Dick Davis's English translation. I loved it so much that I read the stories over and over until the pages and cover got all ripped.

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When I started second grade this year, my teachers asked everyone in class what our biggest dream was. I said my dream was to read the *Shahnameh*...in Persian of course! But that couldn't even fit on the tiny piece of paper they were writing our answers on! Check it out on my poster. That drawing in the middle is supposed to be me - haha!



I think the *Shahnameh* is the best story ever and I want to share it with everybody. And now I'm almost done with second grade and SO excited to share my website! epicofkings.com is coming soon... stay tuned!

When my mom and I were working on the website this week, she asked me a cool question: *"What do you think makes a story truly epic?"*

I had to think about it for kind of a long time. Here's what I came up with:

1. Unforgettable

A truly epic story has to be unforgettable. In the *Shahnameh*, when Sam found out his baby Zal was born with white hair and white skin, he freaked out and left him at the foot of Mount Damavand. Then Simorgh, a gigantic magic bird, carried Zal all the way to the top of the mountain and raised him until he grew up! That's CRAZY. Who's ever heard of a

bird raising a person... let alone a hero?! Another unforgettable story is the battle of Rostam and Sohrab.

2. Emotions

There's this huge battle between Rostam (the greatest hero) and a younger warrior named Sohrab. And neither of them knew they were father and son! Rostam killed Sohrab in the battle, and by the time he found out who Sohrab was, it was too late to save him. That is one of the saddest stories I have ever read. I actually felt SO sad I folded those pages in the book so I wouldn't have to see them again! But not everything in the *Shahnameh* is sad, like Rostam's Seven Trials where he fights through seven impossible challenges to rescue a king! It is so exciting and legendary.

3. Impossible Choices

This one is my favorite, I think. Esfandiyar is a hero who gets ordered by a king (who happens to be his dad) to capture Rostam. But he actually looks up to Rostam and doesn't even want to fight. And Rostam doesn't want to fight him either! But neither of them has a choice because they both promised their kings they would do it, and you can't break a promise like that. What I think is so cool about it is there's no real villain. Both are good guys. They're just stuck. It's kind of like, what do you do when there's no good choice?

4. Conflict

You need all kinds of characters for an epic. Heroes, allies, and really evil villains. Like Afrasiyab, who is basically the ultimate enemy of Persia in the whole *Shahnameh*. He's super powerful and evil and keeps coming back. One of the best parts is when Afrasiyab traps a good guy, Bizhan, and throws him in a dungeon. But Afrasiyab always thinks he's smarter than other people. And that doesn't really go well for him! I don't want to say too much because he shows up again here 🙌

5. Love

I get that love is an important part of a lot of stories but the best epics aren't too mushy. When Bizhan is stuck in that dungeon (remember?!) he gets rescued partly because of a girl named Manijeh. Who is Afrasiyab's own daughter! She was brave to help Bizhan escape.

6. Real History

Ok this is the biggest reason I think the *Shahnameh* is the greatest epic of all time. It's not just mythology. It tells the story of real kings and things that actually happened in ancient Persia thousands of years ago. I love learning about that stuff! Oh and fun fact: a lot of people think if the *Shahnameh* was never written, Persian as a language would have never survived. The author of the *Shahnameh* saved a whole language. WOW.

So those are my reasons. If you've read the *Shahnameh*, what are your reasons?

And if you're wondering what we decided to put on the Epic of Kings website, here's a sneak peek:

WELCOME TO THE GREATEST EPIC EVER WRITTEN.

Legends. Heroes. Villains. Kings. Battles. Love. Heartbreak. Magic birds. Impossible choices.

The Shahnameh is the greatest epic of all time. But its real battle was not fought with swords...

And that's where things start to get really good!

Thanks for reading my first post. See you next time!

Jack

The journey continues at epicofkings.com 👑

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